VARSHA THAKUR

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SUMMARY

Education and skills program professional with nearly six years of experience designing learning pathways, assessments, and knowledge products for government programs serving 1M+ learners across Africa and India, including EdoBEST, a Government of Edo State and World Bank program. Rotary Peace Fellow and master's candidate at UNC-Chapel Hill and interning with UNICEF's Office of Internal Audit and Investigations. I work at the intersection of education, technology and policy.

CORE SKILLS

- AI literacy and AI adoption
- Evaluation rubrics
- Assessment design, KPIs
- Project management
- Policy analysis
- Knowledge management
- Human-centered design
- Education
- Research, documentation

WORK EXPERIENCE

UNICEF, Office of Internal Audit and Investigations — May 2026 – Present

Intern (part-time, remote)

- Analyze information and data for initial assessments and investigations
- Draft case assessments, notes for the record, and advisory reports
- Research UNICEF systems and open-source material to support case assessments
- Use internal AI tools under confidentiality protocols; tested the office's AI transcription tool

NewGlobe Education, India — Jul 2019 – May 2025

Deputy Managing Editor, Instructional Design, New Delhi (2023–2025)

- Developed and rolled out GenAI usage standards
- Trained a 12-person team in prompt engineering, reducing revision cycles by 40%
- Led a team of 10 associates and 2 managers
- Defined KPIs for delivery quality, efficiency, and outcomes; reduced Kenya print costs by 17.8%
- Proposed and led integration of QR-linked phonics audio into homework books
- Piloted with ~100 students in Nigeria, with positive feedback from teachers, students, and parents
- Led delivery of 4,747 books to children in military camps during the May 2023 ethnic conflict in Manipur
- Managed publication of teacher guides, answer keys, homework keys, and exams for all programs

Manager, Instructional Design, Hyderabad (2020–2023)

- Managed a team of 6 associates
- Led the instructional design team that created 800+ assessments for EdoBEST, a government of Edo and the World Bank program in Edo State, Nigeria
- Managed the STAR Education program (500+ teacher guides and 100+ term exams for Class 6–9)

Associate, Instructional Design, Hyderabad (2019–2020)

- Created 1200+ Teacher guides for Nigeria, Uganda, Liberia, Kenya, and India
- Designed 900+ radio lessons during the Covid-19 pandemic for continued learning in Africa
- Designed 450+ Hindi teacher guides and exams for Andhra Pradesh (Grades 3, 4, and 5)

Indian PAC, Uttar Pradesh, India — Jun 2016 – May 2017

Junior Associate / Political Analyst

- Designed 3 election campaigns for the assembly election in Uttar Pradesh and Punjab, India
- Conducted FGDs with community health workers, local journalists, and farmers
- Led field operations for election campaigns in 17 assembly constituencies
- Authored a comprehensive state report highlighting key issues faced by farmers and weavers

EDUCATION

University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill, School of Education Expected May 2027
MA, Educational Innovation, Technology, and Entrepreneurship. Concentration: Innovative Specialist track
Relevant coursework: AI for Learning and Innovation, Statistics, Public Policy

Jawaharlal Nehru University, New Delhi, India May 2016
MA, International Relations. Merit-cum-means scholarship (2014–2016)

University of Delhi, New Delhi, India May 2014
BA (Honors), Political Science

LEADERSHIP AND FELLOWSHIPS

UNC-Chapel Hill Student AI Committee, Ethics Team 2026 – Present
Co-Lead, Ethics Team

- Co-lead the ethics team of a student AI committee reporting to the Office of the Provost, developing evidence-based recommendations on fair, equitable, and informed use of AI in higher education
- Leading a review of course syllabi's AI policies, integration of student survey insights, and analysis of usage and legal policies of major AI companies, including OpenAI and Anthropic

Carolina Diplomacy Fellowship, UNC-Chapel Hill 2026
Fellow

- Skills and networks in diplomacy and international affairs; participant in the Leaders Readers circle

PORTFOLIO AND PUBLICATIONS

- "Towards a Brighter Future: Innovation and AI in the Education Sector," *NSDC Connect*, March 2024, pp. 21–23 [link]
- Peace Lab Project, AI literacy and ethics program for government schools in Bihar, with a stakeholder analysis, theory of change, and two-year roadmap for teacher training and hiring local youth as facilitators; earned a High Pass, presented at Duke and the Rotary Annual Spring Conference
- AI tool for small business owners (group project, in progress), with a system prompt grounded in learning theory that guides owners through a 30-60-90 day plan
- Co-author, 9 foundational literacy and numeracy homework books with QR-linked phonics audio, NewGlobe (2023–2025)

TRAINING AND HONORS

- **Rotary Peace Fellowship:** fully funded master's program, The Rotary Foundation (2025–2027)
- **Direct Instructions lesson design:** a comprehensive 120 hours long course
- **UNESCO MGIEP:** Teachers as Designers and Compassionate Integrity Training

SKILLS AND LANGUAGES

- **Learning tools:** Articulate Rise 360, Articulate Storyline (foundational), Canva, Figma
- **AI tools:** ChatGPT, Claude, Codex, Gemini (audio and video)
- **Data and other:** R, GitHub, Microsoft 365, Google Workspace
- **Languages:** English (fluent), Hindi (native), Maithili (native)
- **Management and leadership competencies:** Knowledge management, Stakeholder management, Team management, Performance evaluation